

Sara Truesdale

Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder
sara.truesdale@colorado.edu | saraktruesdale.com

Last updated: September 2026

Education

Ph.D., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder	2027 (expected)
M.A., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder	2024
M.S., Electrical Engineering, Lehigh University	2010
B.S., Electrical Engineering, Lehigh University	2008

Research Interests

Labor economics, Family economics, Public economics

Job Market Paper

“Children and Household Burden: The Influence of Pre-Birth Couple Norms”

The arrival of a first child is a significant shock to a couple’s household labor arrangement. How does this shock affect couples differently depending on their pre-birth division of housework, and what are the implications for individual’s well-being? Using rich longitudinal data from the Household, Income and Labour Dynamics in Australia Survey, I categorize childless couples based on their division of housework before having children and estimate their differential responses to the arrival of their first child. I find a consistent pattern of a larger increase in household work for those who did less before the birth, relative to others of their gender. The smallest adjustment occurs for couples where the woman did the majority of the housework before the birth, while couples where the man did the majority pre-birth are mostly likely to reverse roles. The individuals’ perception of this reassignment matches the actual change in hours of housework, with women feeling they are doing more than their fair share and men feeling that they are doing less. However, I find no strong differential effect of childbirth or labor reallocation on relationship satisfaction or happiness across different types of couples.

Working Papers

“Childhood Immigrant Neighbors and Integration” with Brian Duncan and Hani Mansour
Does childhood contact with immigrants increase natives’ willingness to integrate with them as adults? We answer this question using the sequential enumeration order of the 1930 U.S. Census, which lets us identify native boys who happened to live immediately next door to a foreign-born child. Conditional on county fixed effects and the spatial distribution of immigrant and native households along a given street, the nativity of the specific next-door neighbor is plausibly random. We find that boys who lived next to a foreign-born child were significantly more likely to marry a foreign-born spouse a decade later. The effect is driven by exposure to immigrant boys rather than girls, and is more than three times larger for exposure between ages 8–12

than for ages 13–17, consistent with a mechanism operating through childhood play and friendship rather than marriage-market access. These findings suggest that the assimilation of immigrants depends not only on their own efforts to integrate, but also on natives’ willingness to welcome them.

Work in Progress

“The Effect of Title IX-induced Adjustment on Girls’ Sports Involvement on Family Formation”

“Labor Market Effects of Postpartum Medicaid Expansion” with Megan Rice

“Stay-at-Home-Fatherhood and Lifetime Household Income”

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Intermediate Microeconomic Theory Spring 2026

University of Colorado Boulder

Instructor, Masters of Economics Math Camp: Probability and Statistics Summer 2026

University of Colorado Denver

Teaching Assistant, Financial Literacy Fall 2026

University of Colorado Boulder

Teaching Assistant, Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Spring 2025

University of Colorado Boulder

Teach Assistant, Principles of Microeconomics Fall 2022, Fall 2025

University of Colorado Boulder

Research Experience

Research Assistant, University of Colorado Boulder - Department of Economics 2024-2026

Prof. Brian Cadena, Prof. Terra McKinnish

Research Assistant, University of Colorado Boulder - Institute of Behavioral Science 2023

Prof. Tania Barnham

Research Assistant, University of Colorado Denver - Department of Economics 2020-2022

Prof. Brian Duncan, Prof. Hani Mansour, Prof. Maulik Jagnani

Honors, Awards, and Grants

Graduate Award for Public Policy Research 2026

Sieglinde Talbott Haller Award, CU Boulder Department of Economics 2025

Leslie Whittington Endowed Fellowship for Excellence in Economics 2023, 2024

Conference Presentations and Invited Talks

2026: CSQIEP Mentoring Conference, CU Population Center (poster, scheduled), United States Air Force Academy (scheduled)

Skills

Software: Stata, Python, L^AT_EX, Matlab

References

Terra McKinnish, Ph.D

Advisor

Department of Economics
University of Colorado Boulder
256 UCB
Boulder, Colorado 80309
Phone:303.492.6770
terra.mckinnish@colorado.edu

Chloe East, Ph.D

Committee Member

Department of Economics
University of Colorado Boulder
256 UCB
Boulder, Colorado 80309
Phone:303.735.5500
chloe.east@colorado.edu

Brian Cadena, Ph.D

Committee Member

Department of Economics
University of Colorado Boulder
256 UCB
Boulder, Colorado 80309
Phone:303.492.7908
brian.cadena@colorado.edu